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# 2026 IT Virtualization Survey: What's Next for VMware Users

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## Executive Summary: VMware Users Are Gaining Control in a Shifting Market

- **Higher Costs Are Driving VMware Customers Away.** Just about all top IT decision-makers surveyed, 90%, are considering leaving VMware/Broadcom due to higher licensing costs (likely resulting from forced product bundles and subscription packages).
- **The End Of VMware Perpetual License Support Is the Beginning Of A New infrastructure Strategy.** A majority, 54%, of current VMware users cite the End of General Support (EoGS) for [all VMware perpetual licenses by October 2027](#) as a reason to consider alternatives. [VMware vSphere 7.x and related products went EoGS effective October 2025.](#)
- **VCF Migration Is Not The Preferred Option For Many.** Close to half of current VMware perpetual license users, 48%, *do not currently plan* to convert any of their VMware assets to Broadcom VMware Cloud Foundation (VCF) subscription.
- **Complexity, Security, And Skills Gaps Remain Key Barriers To IT Virtualization Success.** 40% of top IT decision-makers identified operational complexity as the most pronounced gating factor in achieving their IT virtualization goals. Additional obstacles include multi-vendor management, cited by 38%, and 37% reported concerns about securing the increased attack surface. Another 37% were concerned about team skill requirements.
- **Alternative Hypervisor Platforms Are Being Phased In Now.** A majority of current VMware users, 60%, are considering a multiple hypervisor strategy to include VMware ESXi hypervisors and alternative hypervisors.
- **Third-Party Support Is Rapidly Gaining Popularity.** Nearly half of IT virtualization decision-makers (48%) are considering third-party support. The top drivers include security (60%), installation and implementation support (57%), and service and support concerns (54%).
- **Proactive Security Approaches Rank High In Value.** More than three-fourths of IT virtualization decision-makers surveyed, 77%, reported they see a value in a security solution that allows for proactive protection against vulnerabilities instead of relying on VMware/Broadcom's patching program.
- **Hybrid Containerization And Multiple Hypervisor Environments Are Coming Within Three Years.** There will be increased use of cloud environments—both public and private—to run workloads and applications across multiple hypervisors. Top IT decision-makers cite several key drivers behind the shift to multi-hypervisor and containerized environments: 65% aim to improve operational efficiency, 53% seek to reduce costs for cloud-native applications, and 47% prefer a best-of-both-worlds approach to workload placement.
- **Cost Remains The Primary Driver Of IT Virtualization Roadmaps—Both Short And Long Term.** Nearly three-fourths of final decision-makers (73%) prioritize minimizing costs in their future IT virtualization strategies. Beyond direct cost savings, a majority (64%) also look to IT virtualization platforms to enable scalability and more flexible capacity.

## The Global IT Virtualization Market Still in Flux

The IT virtualization market is driven by the need for cost-effective, scalable infrastructure, with the global market projected to grow significantly due to hybrid cloud adoption, AI-driven workload management, and data center modernization.

This market also continues to rapidly expand. The market stands at about \$110 billion this year, and is projected to grow to \$225 billion by 2031, at a compounded annual growth rate of more than 15%, according to [Mordor Intelligence](#).

In this report, the authors state:

- “Enterprises are revisiting hypervisor budgets after Broadcom converted VMware’s flagship products to subscription-only licensing, which accelerated evaluations of Nutanix AHV, Microsoft Hyper-V, KVM, and other alternatives.”
- “Server consolidation remains a cost lever, while confidential-computing features baked into new silicon from Intel and AMD strengthen compliance postures in healthcare and finance. Competitive momentum is also shifting as hyperscalers embed lightweight hypervisors into infrastructure-as-a-service offerings, blurring the line between private cloud and public cloud procurement.”

Key drivers accelerating the IT virtualization market include:

- **Unsustainable Economics.** Broadcom has changed licensing arrangements and raised the costs of maintaining or continuing with previous VMware products.
- **Hybrid and Multi-Cloud Adoption.** Organizations are increasingly adopting hybrid server virtualization (VM) and cloud strategies, as well as containerization, to blend private infrastructure with public cloud services, requiring advanced IT virtualization to manage workloads across diverse environments.
- **Increased Vendor and Environment Complexity.** IT virtualization environments become a mix of technologies from vendors, which creates skill gaps and security risks.

Third-party support and security providers can deliver service support and security to reduce operational complexity while hardening these hybrid IT virtualization stacks.

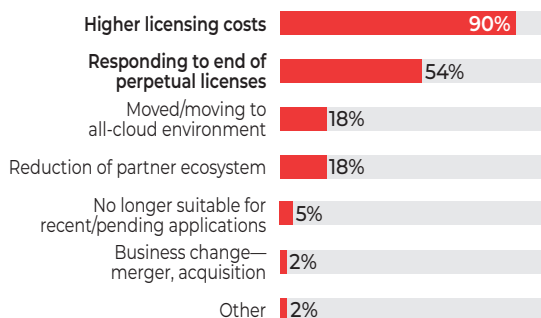
- **Improved Security and Compliance.** The rise of sophisticated cyber threats has compelled organizations to fortify security at the hypervisor layer, enhancing workload isolation and regulatory compliance.
- **Cost Optimization and Server Consolidation.** The shift toward more efficient data centers is driven by the need to reduce capital expenditure (CapEx) on hardware and operational costs (OpEx).
- **AI and Automation Integration.** The integration of AI and AI-driven automation allows for smarter workload management and optimized resource allocation.
- **Edge Computing Expansion.** The rapid deployment of edge computing, where processing is needed closer to data sources, is significantly accelerating IT virtualization adoption.
- **Digital Transformation Initiatives.** The need to modernize outdated IT infrastructure and support Agile/DevOps methodologies encourages the adoption of virtualized environments.

## Strategic Shifts for VMware Users

Higher costs are driving VMware customers away, and just about all top IT decision-makers are poised to make a migration move.

About 90% of top IT virtualization decision-makers surveyed are considering leaving VMware/Broadcom due to higher costs resulting from forced product bundles and subscription packages. A majority, 54%, also cite the End of General Support (EoGS) for all [VMware perpetual licenses by October 2027 as a reason to consider alternatives. VMware vSphere 7.x and related products went EoGS effective October 2025.](#) (Figure 3-1)

**Figure 3-1 — Why are you or will you be moving away from VMware/Broadcom? (Among the top decision makers)**

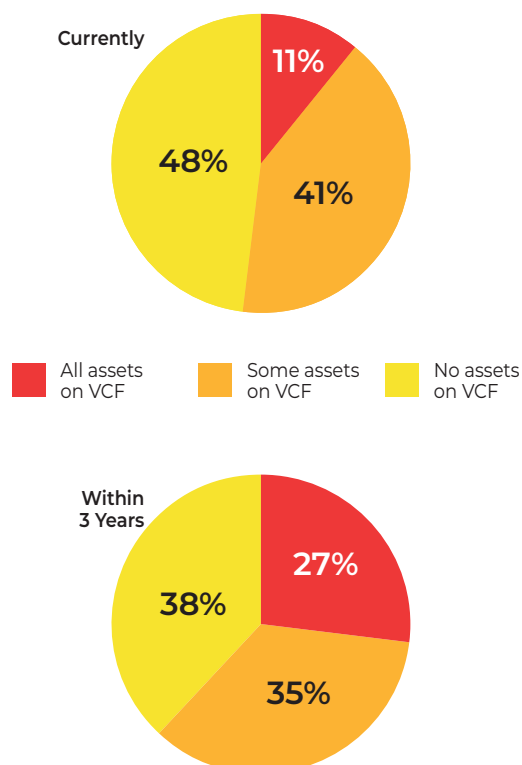


**The End of VMware Licensing Support is Generating Uncertainty.** While the IT virtualization market continues to be robust and expanding, doubts now overshadow the VMware customer base. Broadcom has announced the end of general support for VMware vSphere 7 and vSphere 8, as well as related product versions. These include VMware ESXi, vSAN, and vCenter. There are a considerable number of organizations globally that are not ready to migrate from their existing VMware perpetual licenses to VMware subscription models, citing concerns around stability, costs, and compatibility with existing workloads. Amid uncertainty stemming

from Broadcom's changes to VMware licensing and the broader shift toward more flexible cloud- and container-based options, surveyed IT leaders indicate plans to explore alternatives beyond VMware's traditional on-premises offerings.

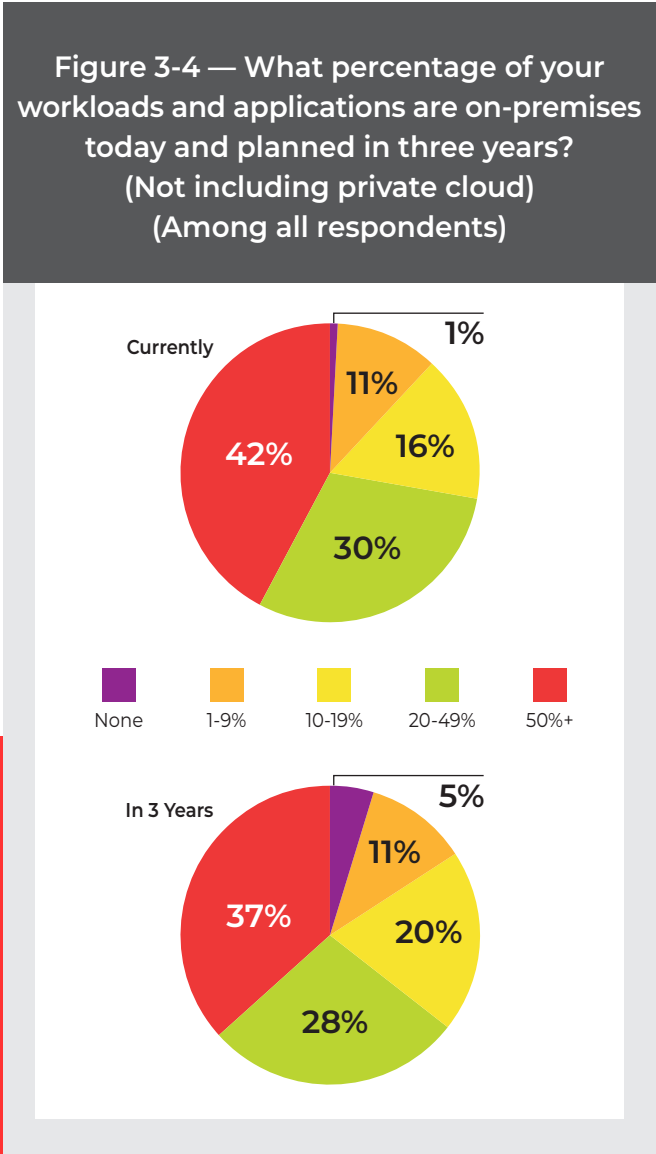
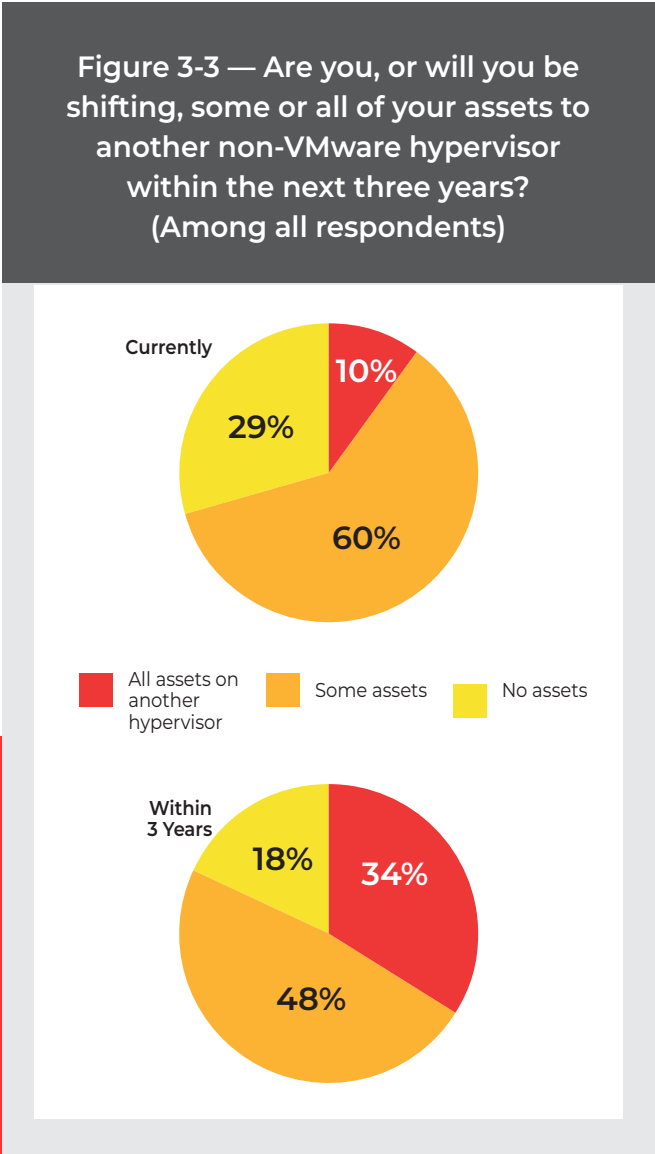
**VCF Migration is Not an Option for Many.** About half of all current VMware perpetual license users (48%) *do not plan* to convert any of their VMware assets to Broadcom VMware Cloud Foundation (VCF) subscription within the next 12 months. (Figure 3-2)

**Figure 3-2 — Are you, or will you be shifting, some or all of your assets to the VMware Cloud Foundation subscription offering within the next three years? (Among all respondents)**

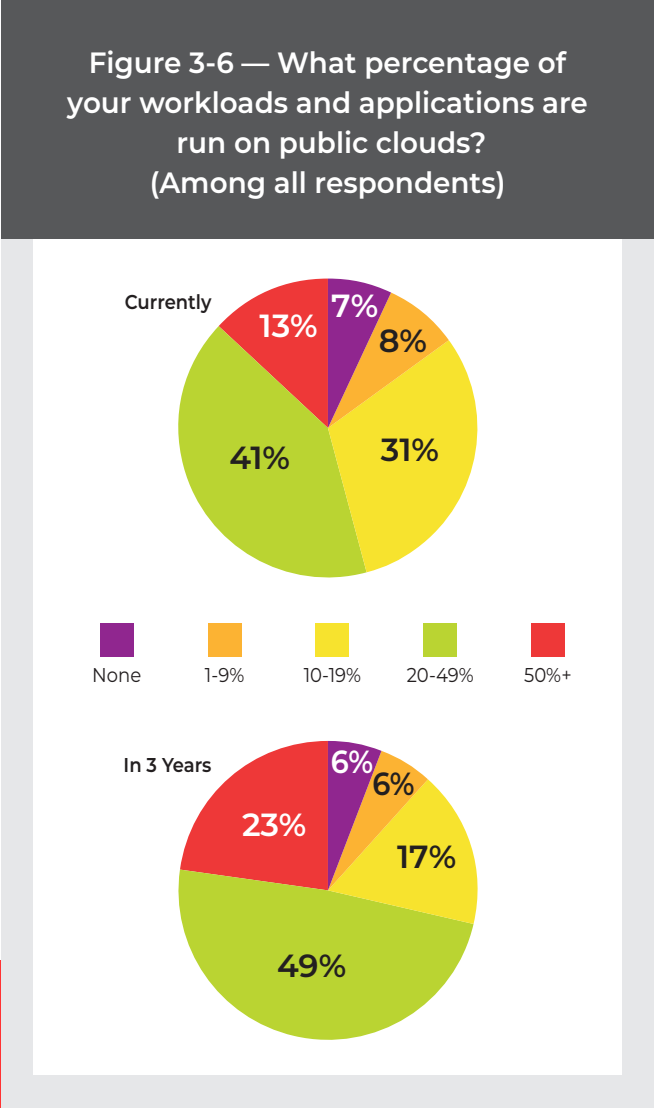
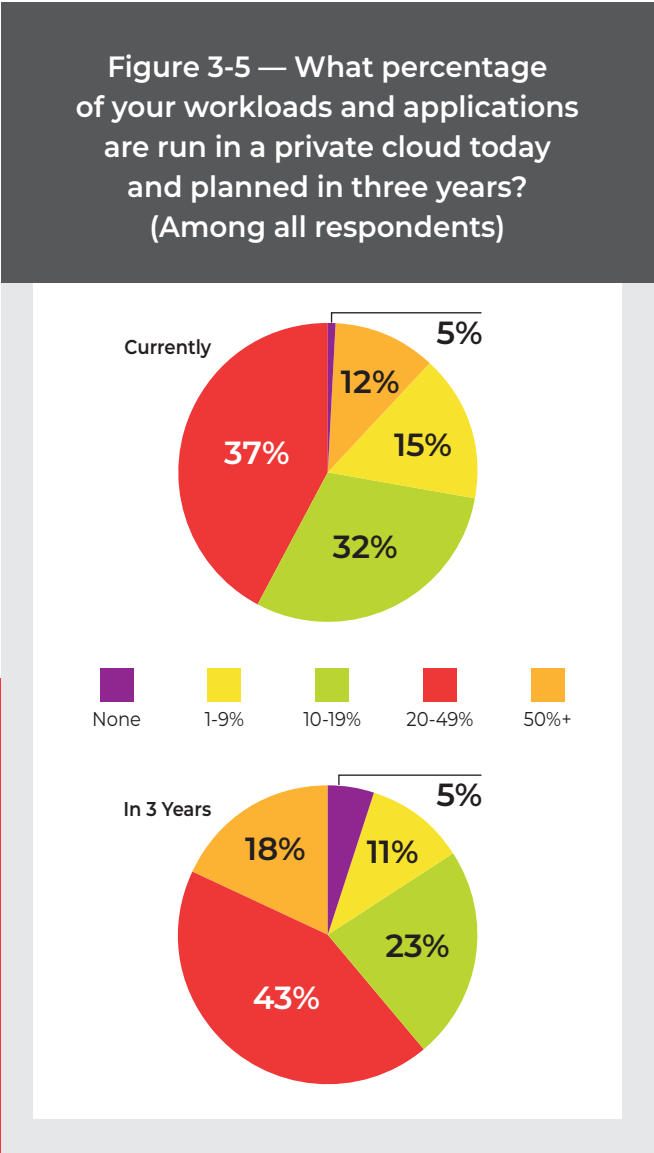


Tellingly, the percentage of VMware users planning to shift to non-VMware hypervisors will triple over the next three years, rising from 10% currently to 34%. Overall, 82% plan to have at least some assets outside of VMware. (Figure 3-3)

As cloud adoption rises and IT virtualization engines evolve, there will be movement away from on-premises workloads and applications, the survey also shows. While 42% indicate a majority of their assets are now on-premises, this will decline to 37% over the next three years. (Figure 3-4)



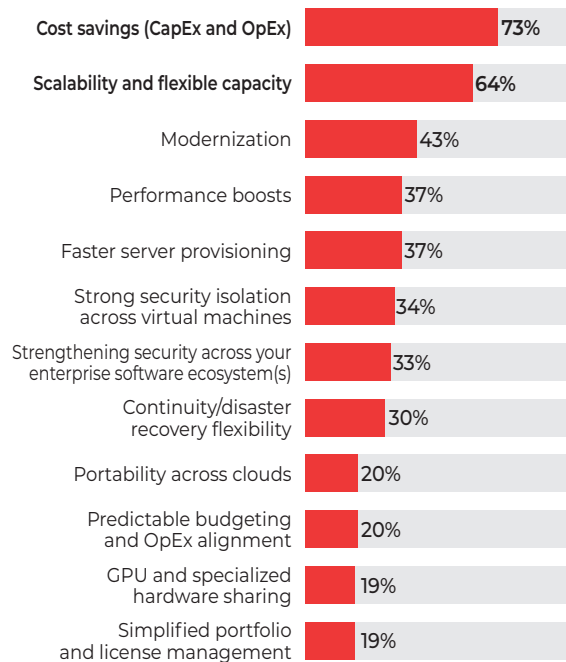
Both private and public cloud adoption are on the rise as an avenue to IT virtualization. For private clouds, the percentage using these platforms for a majority of their workloads and applications will increase from 12% to 18% over the next three years. (Figure 3-5) The percentage of users deploying most of their assets to the public cloud will almost double, rising from 13% currently to 23% within three years. (Figure 3-6)



## Building a Vendor-Independent Roadmap

**The Main Goal of IT Virtualization Roadmaps is Cost Savings.** What dominates IT virtualization roadmaps in the near future? Close to three-fourths of the top decision-makers in the survey (73%) seek to minimize costs in their IT virtualization technology plans. This aligns with the primary reason noted earlier: 90% of customers indicate they are scaling back or discontinuing their Broadcom licensing arrangements. It's not just about pure cost savings, either: a majority (64%) also expresses a need to leverage IT virtualization platforms to achieve scalability and flexible capacity. (See Figure 4-1)

**Figure 4-1 — What are the current goals for your IT virtualization roadmap? (Among the top decision-makers)**

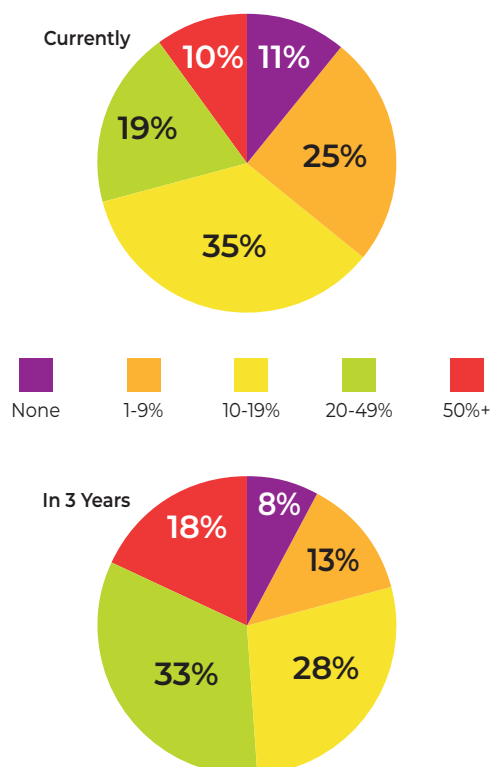


### There is a Noticeable Pivot Toward Containerization.

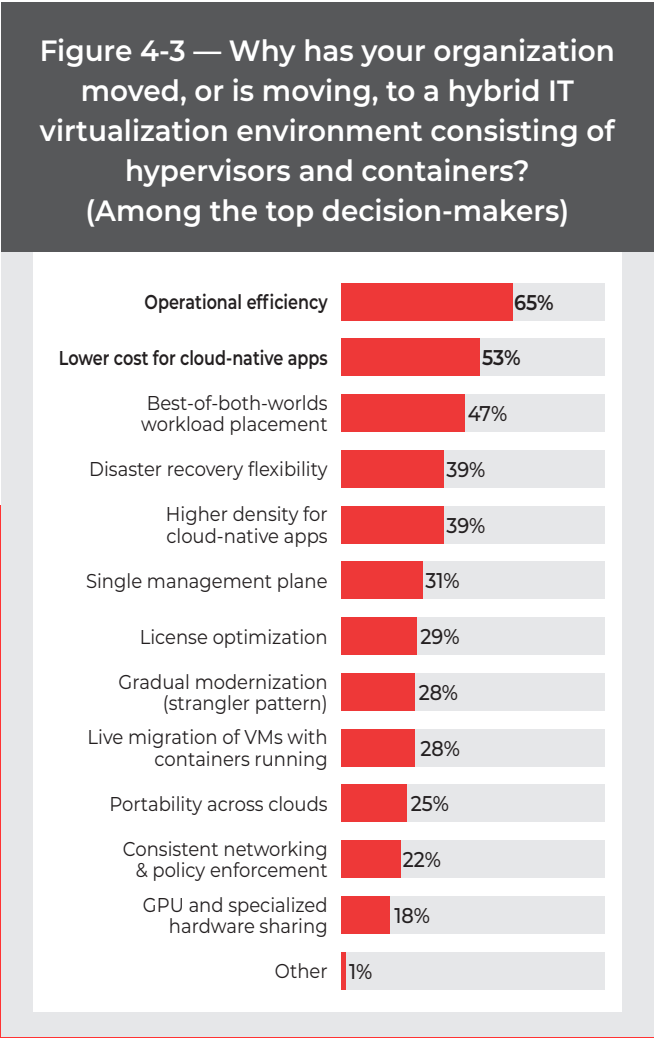
IT Infrastructure and Operations (I&O) leaders are also considering a shift from virtual machines to containerization to unlock superior efficiency, portability, and agility. By sharing the host OS kernel, containers are lighter weight than hypervisor-driven virtual machines, allowing for better resource utilization and near-instant scaling for microservices.

Because they bundle applications with all necessary dependencies, containers ensure a “build once, run anywhere” workflow that eliminates environment-related bugs. Ultimately, this technology streamlines DevOps pipelines and provides a consistent operational framework across hybrid and multi-cloud environments. The percentage who will be moving most of their applications and assets to containers is expected to grow from 10% to 18%. (Figure 4-2)

**Figure 4-2 — What percentage of your workloads and applications are run on containerized approaches?**



Operational efficiency and lower cloud costs are driving many decisions to move to containers, as cited by 65% and 53% of decision-maker respondents. (Figure 4-3) At the same time, IT leaders are increasingly adopting a blended infrastructure strategy that combines hypervisors and containers to leverage the unique strengths of both technologies, rather than treating them as competitors. Close to half, 47%, favor a “best of both worlds” scenario: it offers the agility and speed of containers while utilizing the robust security, networking, and management tools of existing IT virtualization platforms.



While containers offer lightweight, portable application packaging for microservices, hypervisors provide mature, hardware-level isolation for security and legacy application support. A dominant trend is running container orchestration systems, such as Kubernetes, inside virtual machines. This unified architecture allows enterprises to securely consolidate workloads, running legacy applications and modern cloud-native apps on the same hardware, which aids in modernization efforts, improves resource utilization, and provides a clear migration path.

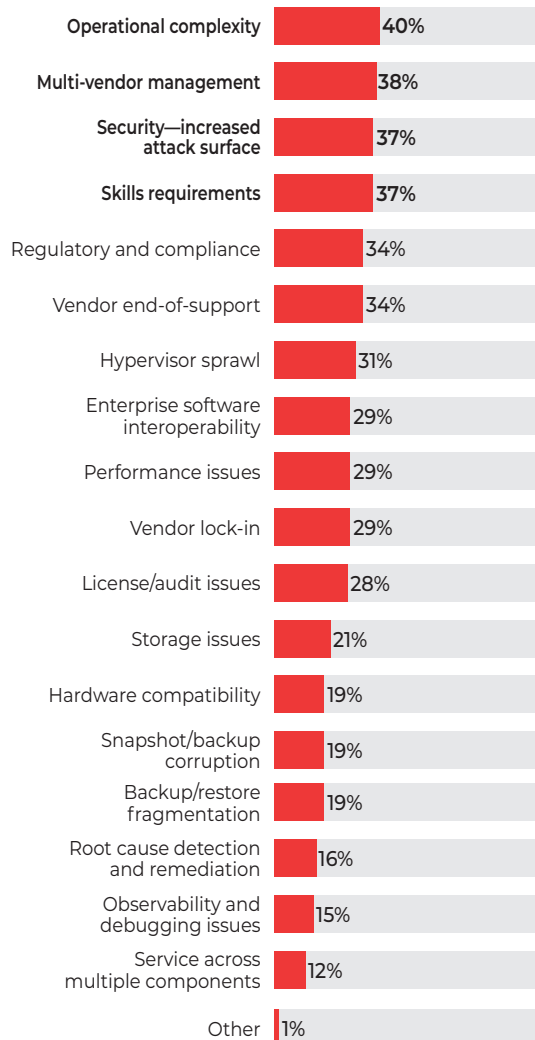
Furthermore, this strategy is highly prevalent at the edge, where VMs enable strict isolation for multi-tenancy, and containers enable high-density AI and data processing workflows, say industry sources.

**Complexity, Security, and Skills Gaps Remain Key Barriers to IT Virtualization Success.** Ironically, operational complexity is the most cited challenge (40%), despite virtualization’s promise to simplify IT environments. Other leading obstacles include managing multi-vendor ecosystems (38%), securing an expanded attack surface (37%), and addressing skills gaps (37%) (Figure 4-4). These findings highlight the value of experienced technology and service partners that can provide the expertise, automation, and integrated solutions needed to reduce complexity and accelerate IT virtualization initiatives.

**Platform Migration is Challenging.** Modernization in IT virtualization aims to create an environment that is automated, secure by design, and transparent. The move toward AI and real-time visibility suggests a shift toward self-healing infrastructure that reduces the burden on overstretched IT staff. However, IT virtualization decision-makers recognize that shifting or adding a new platform is more challenging than anticipated.

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**Figure 4-4 — What are the main barriers to achieving the goals of your IT virtualization roadmap? (Among the top decision-makers)**



Open-ended responses point to migration planning and implementation as the most frequently cited challenge in meeting IT virtualization goals. Security updates and patching also emerged as a common concern, underscoring the ongoing demands of maintaining secure environments. In addition, respondents referenced skills gaps, limited real-time visibility, and the complexity of integrating AI as notable barriers. (Figure 4-5)

**Figure 4-5 — Areas Where Assistance is Needed for IT Virtualization (Top write-in responses)**

1. Migration planning and implementation
2. Security updates and patching
3. Filling skills gaps
4. Attaining real-time visibility
5. Integrating artificial intelligence

## Protecting Mission-Critical Assets in a Multi-Platform World

Hybrid and multi-vendor solutions offer greater flexibility, but they also bring security headaches.

While costs are the primary reason for moving away from Broadcom/VMware, they may also be an issue with a more mixed stack. Also paradoxically, while greater security is seen as the leading goal for hybrid or multi-vendor solutions, it also stands in the way of efforts to move in this direction.

Security teams are overwhelmed by the “vulnerability treadmill.” In a virtualized environment, a single unpatched hypervisor can expose hundreds of guest machines. Leaders are admitting that their manual patching processes are too slow to stop modern zero-day exploits.

**Increased System Vulnerability in Hybrid IT Virtualization Environments.** The identification of these critical gaps (see Figure 5-1) by top security decision-makers signals a significant shift in the IT virtualization market. These results suggest that traditional IT virtualization security is no longer meeting the demands of modern enterprise environments, creating a “perfect storm” of operational risk and technical debt.

The combination of **exposure to security threats** and a lack of **real-time visibility** means organizations are essentially flying blind. Without real-time insights, the “dwell time”—the duration an attacker stays in a network before being detected—increases significantly. This makes the infrastructure a high-value target for ransomware and advanced persistent threats (APTs).

Integration with existing security solutions or infrastructure stands out as the most oft-cited challenge in addressing IT virtualization security. With uncertainty and complexity comes the need for consultants, who often need to be brought in to assist. Closely linked to security requirements is compliance, which means consequences if data is not adequately protected. (Figure 5-2)

**Figure 5-1 — Critical IT Virtualization Security Gaps**  
(Top write-in responses from decision-makers)

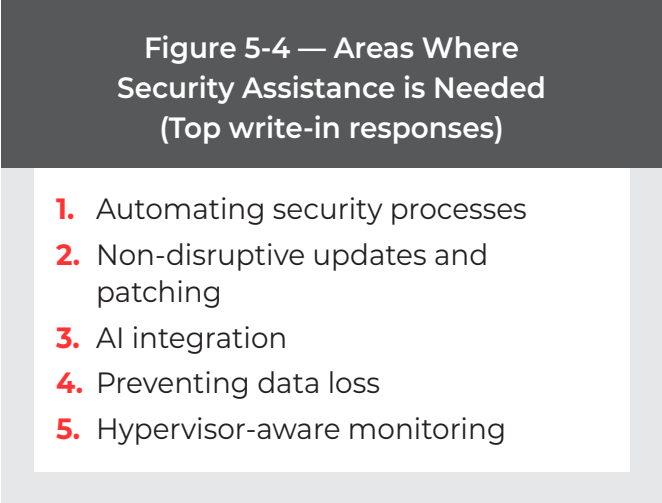
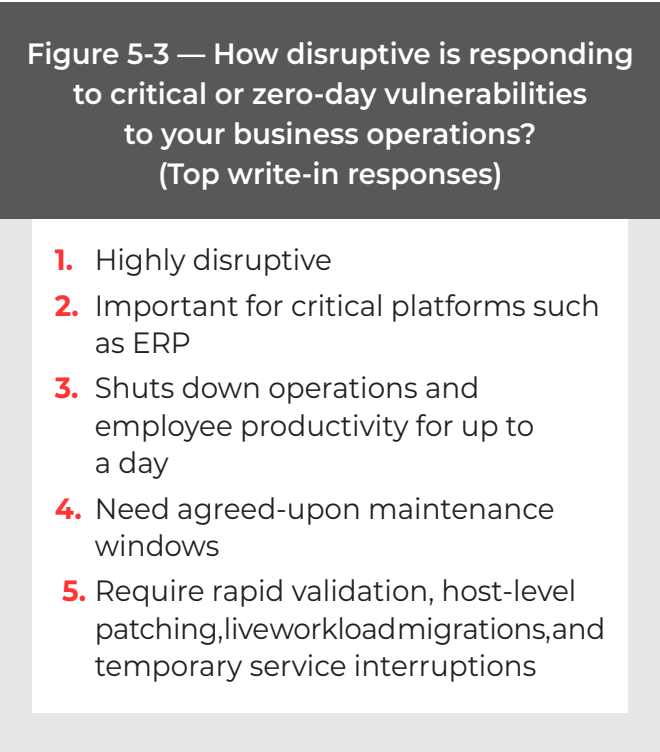
1. Exposure to security threats
2. Doesn't integrate with existing security solutions
3. Follow-up service/troubleshooting
4. Performance overhead
5. Real-time visibility

**Figure 5-2 — Most Common IT Virtualization Security Challenges**  
(Top responses from decision-makers)

1. Integration with current security solutions
2. Need to hire consultants
3. Compliance challenges
4. Maintaining consistent security controls across a dynamic virtual environment
5. AI-powered attacks

**IT Virtualization Security Leaders Want to Shift from Reactive to Resilient.** For IT virtualization leaders, the transition from reactive to resilient requires moving away from the “stop-and-fix” cycle that defines traditional patching. Instead of treating zero-day vulnerabilities as emergency disruptions that paralyze productivity, leaders are seeking a **security-by-design** posture where protection is decoupled from the underlying hardware. Disruption to ongoing operations was cited by many respondents as they respond to security or zero-day challenges. (Figure 5-3)

This shift involves adopting technologies like micro-segmentation, virtual patching, and AI-driven threat detection to shield environments in real time. Ultimately, the goal is to create an “invisible,” runtime-based security layer that maintains operational continuity, ensuring that a critical vulnerability remains a manageable background task rather than a business-halting event. Appropriately, automating security concerns is cited as one of the leading areas where they seek assistance. ERP systems, known for their complexity, also often require assistance. (Figure 5-4)

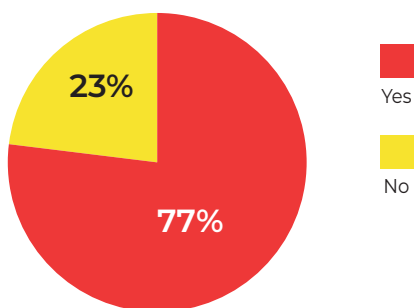


Runtime-based advanced hypervisor security represents a paradigm shift from traditional “outside-in” security to “inside-out” protection. Instead of just guarding the perimeter or scanning files at rest, it monitors the actual behavior of the hypervisor and its virtual machines while they are actively running.

#### **Proactive Security Approaches Valued and Sought.**

More than three-quarters (77%) of IT virtualization decision-makers surveyed reported seeing value in a security solution that enables proactive protection against vulnerabilities rather than relying on VMware/ Broadcom’s patching program. (Figure 5-5)

**Figure 5-5 — Would you see value in a security solution that allows you to be proactively protected against vulnerabilities instead of relying on Broadcom’s patching program? (Responses from decision-makers)**



Advanced hypervisor security and proactive runtime protection constitute a “Tier 0” or “zero-day” defense strategy designed to secure the virtual machine monitor (VMM) layer, which is essential for protecting the entire virtualized infrastructure.

Unlike traditional reactive security, which often fails to protect the hypervisor itself, advanced hypervisor security uses multiple layers of control including AI/ ML-driven behavioral analysis to detect ransomware, fileless attacks, and “VM escape” attempts in

real time, providing protection against zero-day threats. Proactive protection involves hardening the hypervisor environment by employing memory introspection to monitor for malicious activity outside the guest operating system, restricting access to the management interface with multi-factor authentication (MFA), and enforcing strict micro-segmentation.

By operating outside the guest OS, advanced hypervisor security solutions ensure tamper-resistant protection and provide comprehensive visibility, often with minimal performance impact. These strategies are critical in modern data centers and cloud environments (such as VMware ESXi, Linux-based or KVM-based hypervisors) to contain breaches and prevent lateral movement of threats before they can disrupt operations.



## How AIOps is Modernizing IT Virtualization

Many of the workloads running across enterprises now involve AI or machine learning, making it essential for IT virtualization environments to both incorporate AI capabilities and benefit from them.

Vendors are embedding AI directly into their platforms, making these capabilities readily accessible to IT teams. At the same time, a growing ecosystem of models and tools is emerging to support the development of more responsive, intelligent functionality across increasingly complex, multi-layered IT stacks.

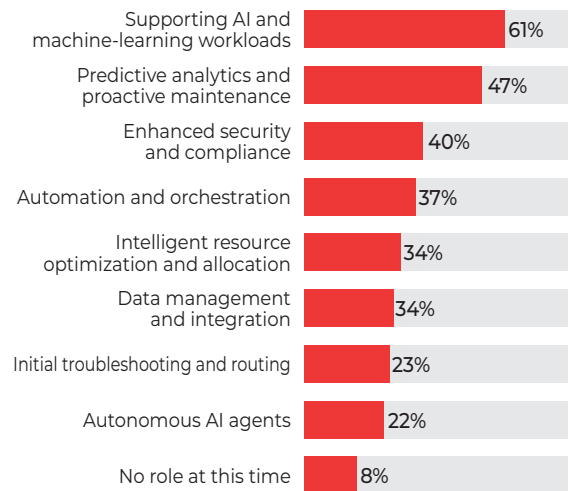
**Data Centers and AI Put IT Virtualization in the Spotlight.** The surge in AI workload demands requires massive, flexible, and high-density compute resources as found in data centers. IT virtualization is essential for managing, optimizing, and scaling this infrastructure efficiently. Data center sprawl is becoming an issue, to the point in which it is becoming headline news. IT virtualization software is the sure path to server consolidation, enabling organizations to reduce the number of servers they are managing.

### AIOps Serves as a ‘Force Multiplier’ for Efficiency.

IT virtualization decision-makers look to AI to perform these top-ranked use cases as it relates to their roadmaps: Supporting AI and machine learning workloads (61%), predictive analytics and proactive maintenance (47%), enhanced security and compliance (40%). Only 22% are looking to autonomous AI agents at this time to support their IT virtualization strategies. (Figure 6-1)

**AIOps Augments IT Teams.** AIOps automates the “heavy lifting” of IT virtualization management, allowing overstretched IT teams to manage increasingly complex environments without a linear increase in headcount. Additionally, AIOps is being considered to transform the hypervisor from a static resource pool into a dynamic, self-aware ecosystem. This includes the ability to monitor, in real time, the performance and actions of their IT virtualization workloads, cited as a top benefit by decision-makers in the survey. The ability to deliver greater productivity is also recognized as a key benefit. (Figure-6-2)

**Figure 6-1 — What is the role of artificial intelligence in your IT virtualization roadmap? (Among all respondents)**



**Figure 6-2 — Benefits of Applying AI to IT Virtualization? (Top write-in responses from decision-makers)**

1. Monitoring virtualization workloads
2. Advancing productivity and efficiencies
3. Enabling AIOps
4. Predictive capabilities
5. Real-time analysis of workloads

AIOps use cases within IT virtualization span:

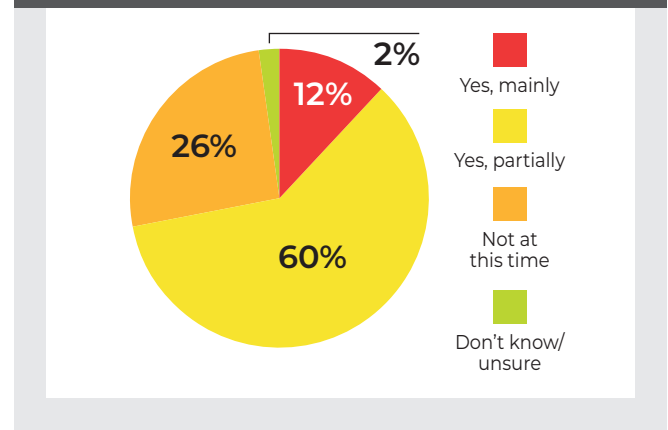
- **Intelligent Resource Orchestration.** Decision-makers leverage AIOps to balance the massive, unpredictable resource demands of **AI and machine learning workloads** against traditional business applications, ensuring high-priority tasks never lack compute power.
- **Predictive Performance Analytics.** The shift toward **predictive analytics and proactive maintenance** fundamentally alters the operational model. AIOps identifies subtle patterns of hardware degradation or virtual network congestion, enabling “preemptive optimization” before these issues lead to costly downtime.
- **Deep-Stack Security.** By automating the detection of anomalous behaviors at the **hypervisor level**, AIOps is considered to bolster security and compliance, identifying “east-west” threats that traditional perimeter tools often miss.

#### There is an AI Readiness Gap within IT

**Virtualization.** While there is massive enthusiasm for AIOps, the human talent required to actually deploy and manage it is struggling to keep pace with the technology. **88% of organizations** (combining “Partially,” “Not at this time,” and “Unsure”) lack the full expertise needed to execute their AI roadmaps. (Figure 6-3)

These teams likely understand the concepts of AI but lack the specialized skills for **data engineering** and **model validation specifically for IT virtualization**. This “**partial**” knowledge often leads to “Pilot Purgatory,” where AI projects are started as small experiments but fail to scale because the team hits a technical ceiling during full production rollout.

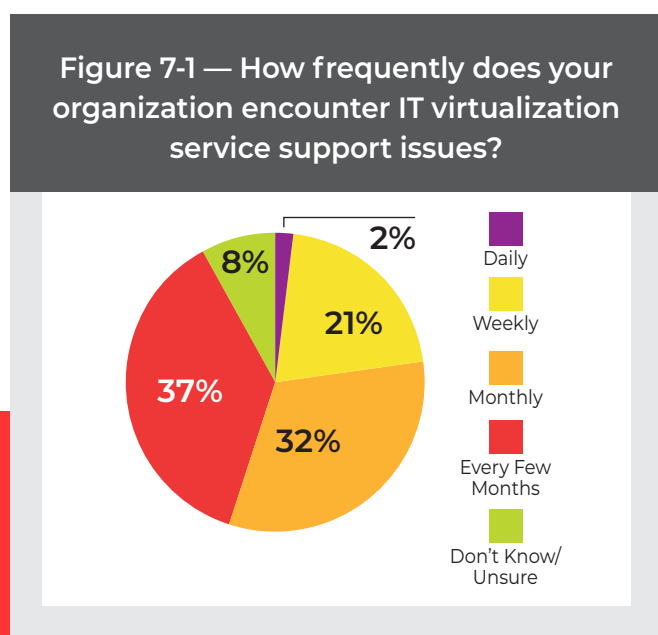
Figure 6-3 — Do your teams have the skills needed to fully implement AI within your IT virtualization framework? (Among all respondents)



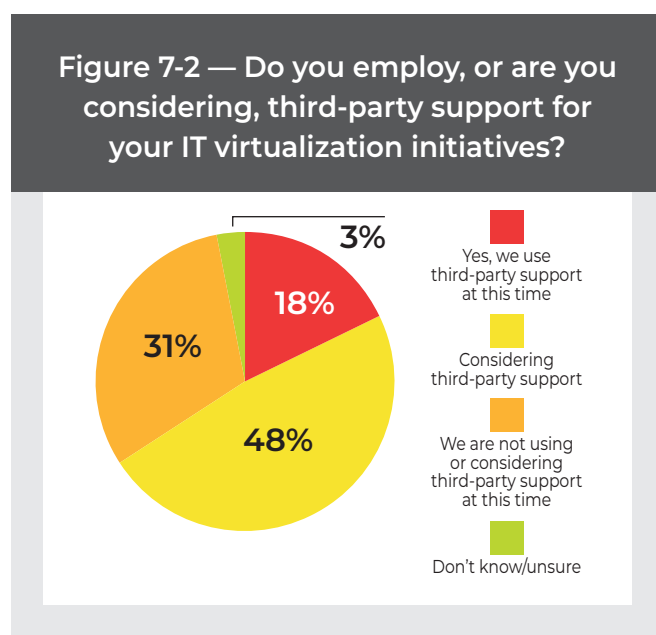
## Third-Party Support as the Liberation Lever

As IT virtualization environments become more complex and multi-hypervisor strategies gain traction, organizations are increasingly turning to external expertise to manage operational, security, and support challenges.

**Service Support Issues are Common.** Nearly one-quarter (21%) of organizations experience service support issues weekly or more often. (Figure 7-1) Close to two-thirds are dissatisfied with Broadcom's patching program and are seeking more proactive protection against vulnerabilities. At the same time, only a small percentage rate the OEM engineers or support teams they rely on as "very skilled."



**Third-Party Support Offers a Proven Path to Operational Freedom.** Two-thirds of respondents, 66%, are employing or considering third-party support to move their IT virtualization initiatives forward. (Figure 7-2)



This growing interest reflects a broader shift in how organizations view support. Rather than relying exclusively on OEMs, many are prioritizing partners that can help maintain uptime, reduce operational burden, and navigate increasingly complex environments.

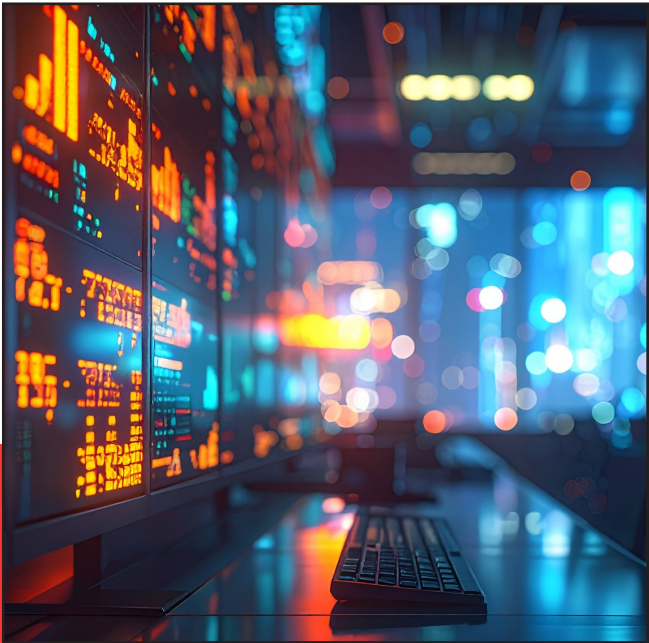
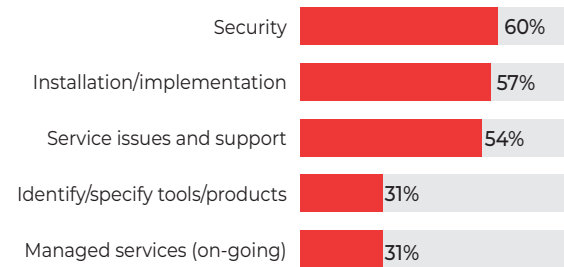
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However, not all third-party support providers offer the same value. Organizations evaluating providers should look for demonstrated expertise across heterogeneous IT virtualization environments, proactive security and vulnerability management capabilities, strong service-level commitments, and the ability to provide strategic guidance for modernization initiatives. As IT virtualization environments become more complex, the most effective partners extend beyond break-fix support to help organizations reduce operational friction, strengthen security, and free internal teams to focus on higher-value priorities.

IT virtualization is no longer a “set-it-and-forget-it” technology. Managing multiple platforms such as VMware, KVM, and Nutanix introduces operational friction that can consume valuable IT resources. Organizations that are frequently addressing support issues have less capacity to focus on strategic priorities such as AIOps, automation, and broader IT modernization efforts.

As IT virtualization environments become more hybrid and multi-vendor, operational, support, and security demands continue to grow. The 48% of IT virtualization decision-makers considering third-party support are not simply looking for lower costs; they are seeking stronger security, implementation expertise, and ongoing service support to help manage this complexity. (Figure 7-3)

Figure 7-3 — For what functions are you using third-party support?



## Key Takeaways for the New IT Virtualization Era

The IT virtualization market is now at a critical inflection point. Rising costs, licensing changes, and the end of perpetual support under Broadcom's VMware model are accelerating a shift away from traditional, single-vendor environments. IT leaders are no longer simply optimizing within VMware ecosystems. They are actively reevaluating their strategies and exploring alternatives.

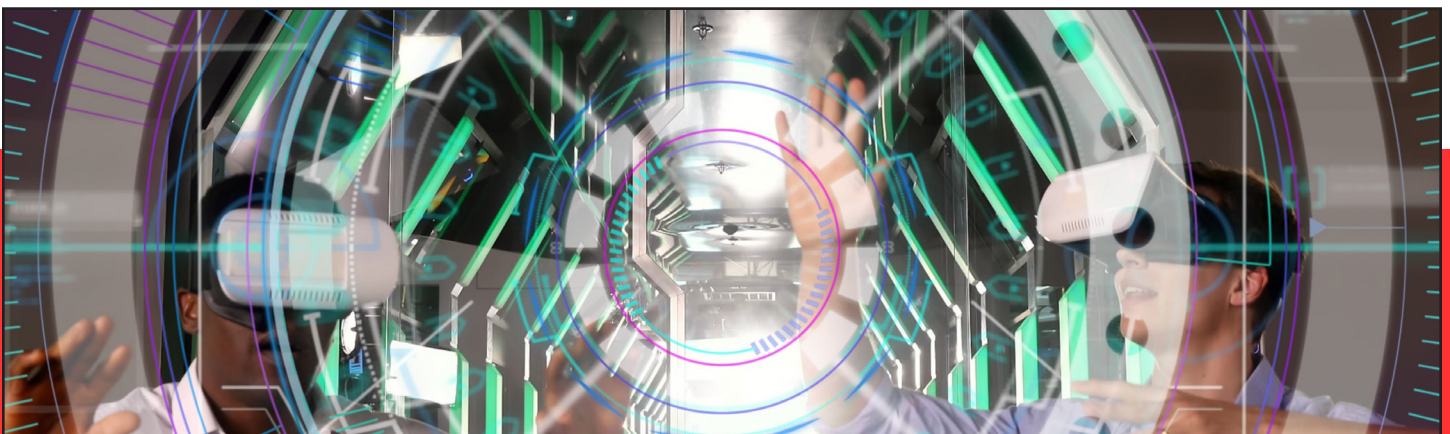
At the same time, organizations are not making immediate, wholesale exits. Instead, they are moving toward more flexible, diversified architectures. Multi-hypervisor strategies, hybrid cloud adoption, and containerized environments are emerging as the preferred path forward, driven by the need for cost control, scalability, and operational efficiency.

This transition comes with challenges. Complexity, security risks, and ongoing skills gaps remain significant barriers. These pressures are increasing demand for third-party support and more proactive security approaches, particularly as organizations look to extend the life of existing environments while evaluating longer-term platform strategies.

Ultimately, the future of IT virtualization will be defined by flexibility, cost efficiency, and reduced single vendor dependency. Organizations that successfully navigate this shift will balance innovation with operational control, using a broader ecosystem of technologies and partners to build more resilient and adaptable infrastructure strategies.

The shift toward this more flexible infrastructure is further accelerated by the integration of AIOps, which serves as a critical force multiplier for efficiency. By leveraging predictive analytics and machine learning, AIOps enables IT teams to manage these increasingly diverse environments without a linear increase in headcount. It transforms the operational model from "reactive firefighting" to "preemptive optimization," identifying subtle patterns of hardware degradation or traffic congestion before they manifest as downtime. This intelligent orchestration allows leaders to balance the massive resource demands of modern AI workloads against traditional business tasks, ensuring the data center remains performant even as it grows in complexity.

To protect these new, diversified architectures, organizations are increasingly turning toward runtime-based advanced hypervisor security. Unlike traditional perimeter-based tools, runtime security provides "inside-out" protection by monitoring the actual behavior of the hypervisor and its workloads in real time. This approach allows for memory



introspection and zero-day exploit prevention that can stop threats—such as ransomware or fileless malware—at the execution layer before they can spread laterally. By implementing this deep-stack visibility, IT leaders can achieve a “self-defending” infrastructure that maintains high availability and continuous security without the performance overhead or operational disruption typically associated with legacy patching cycles.

To streamline complexity and manage multiple vendors, IT infrastructure and operations leaders are increasingly considering **specialized third-party support to deliver “multiple vendor overlay” services for both maintenance and security.** These independent, third-party support providers offer a unified layer of expertise spanning multiple hypervisors and hybrid cloud platforms, effectively decoupling a company’s operational stability from any single manufacturer’s roadmap. IT teams can also maintain high availability and proactive defense without being forced into restrictive, high-cost OEM renewal cycles.

## What Rimini Street Offers

### Rimini Support™ for VMware

- Full portfolio coverage: Stabilize more VMware products, including Horizon.



- No forced upgrades: Run current software and hardware for years.
- Elite expertise: Gain direct access to skilled senior engineers.

### Rimini Protect™ Advanced Hypervisor Security, powered by Vali Cyber®

- Proactive defense: Get zero-day, real-time threat detection to stop malware, ransomware and other threats in their tracks.
- Real-time file remediation: Avoid downtime during or after an attack by preserving critical files.
- Stability and continuity: Implement without any need for operating system or code changes.

Switching to third-party support for VMware from Rimini Street isn't just about cost savings — it's about control, resilience and flexibility.

- Get exceptional, 24/7/365 support from a global service delivery team of 1,000+ full-time engineers.
- Detect and stop attacks in real time across VMware and other commonly deployed hypervisors.
- Buy time and optionality with vendor-agnostic roadmap, implementation and license advisory services from Rimini Consult™.

**[Learn more about Rimini Street solutions for VMware.](#)**

## Survey Demographics

Unisphere Research surveyed 269 executives, managers, and professionals across VMware user organizations to assess their plans and perspectives. This study was conducted by Unisphere Research, a division of Information Today, in partnership with Rimini Street.

The survey was fielded between December 2025 and February 2026, reaching global IT virtualization and infrastructure security decision-makers and key influencers across various industry sectors. Thirty-one percent of respondents were the primary decision-makers for IT virtualization. For more strategic deployments, the analysis focuses on the intentions of these senior decision-makers. All respondents were current users of Broadcom/VMware solutions at the time the survey was conducted.

This survey captures VMware customer intentions following Broadcom's announced changes, focusing on current usage, future plans, and perceptions of VMware under Broadcom, as well as alternative solutions.

## Terms and Definitions

**AIOps: (Artificial Intelligence for IT Operations):** The application of machine learning, big data analytics, and automation to enhance IT operations. It enables organizations to proactively detect, analyze, and resolve IT performance issues in real time, reducing downtime, manual effort, and alert fatigue

**Cloud-based IT Virtualization Solutions:** Comprised of private and public cloud (or hyperscalers) that pool and automate virtual resources

**Containerization:** Bridges legacy VM workloads with containerized applications by running multiple virtual machines on a shared operating system

**Data Center:** A data center is a physical, secure facility that centralizes an organization's IT operations, equipment, and data. It houses networked computers, storage systems, and computing infrastructure (servers, routers, switches) to store, process, and distribute large amounts of data.

**IT Virtualization:** The process of using software to simulate physical hardware, transforming dedicated physical servers, storage, and networking into virtualized, software-defined resources. It enables running multiple, isolated operating systems and applications on a single machine, drastically improving resource utilization, reducing physical footprint, and increasing agility

**Micro-segmentation:** A security approach that divides a network into small, secure zones to isolate workloads and individual devices. By applying granular, software-defined policies (often using a Zero Trust approach), it limits "east-west" movement of threats, reducing the attack surface and containing breaches

**Virtual Machine (VM):** The software-defined abstraction layer within a data center, transforming physical hardware (servers, storage, networking) into flexible, digital resources. This relationship enables server consolidation, improved utilization, reduced physical footprint, and automated management, allowing a single physical server to host multiple virtual machines (VMs).

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